

Module 12: Media, Narratives, and Representation

Service Learning Project

Counter-Narrative Studio: Ethical Storytelling with a Community Partner

Overview

Work with a community media, storytelling, or advocacy organization to produce ethically-sourced content that counters a stereotyped migration narrative — with community members as authors, not subjects.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Identify media bias in circulating coverage (UG 1)
- Analyze narratives and their construction (UG 2)
- Explain how narratives shape perception (UG 3)
- Compare sources critically (UG 4)

Suggested community partners

- Community media outlets and ethnic press
- Storytelling/advocacy organizations (Define American-style campus chapters)
- Immigrant-led cultural organizations wanting communications help
- University media labs partnering with community groups

Project steps

1. Audit current local or national coverage of one migration topic: code the frames, sources quoted, and images used.
2. Meet the partner and community storytellers; learn the partner's consent and editorial standards.
3. Support production of counter-narrative content in the partner's medium (video, photo essay, social series, zine) — community members hold creative control.
4. Apply module frameworks: what frame does the new content construct, and why is it fairer than the one it answers?
5. Publish/share through the partner's channels with their approval.
6. Write the framing analysis connecting the audit to the produced content.

Deliverables

- Coverage audit with coded framing analysis
- Contribution to partner-approved media content
- 3-page framing analysis

Time commitment

15–18 hours.

Ethics requirements

Community members control their own stories and approve all published material; no image or story is used without documented consent.

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Rigor of the coverage audit 30%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: rigor of the coverage audit goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: rigor of the coverage audit is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: rigor of the coverage audit is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: rigor of the coverage audit is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Ethical process — consent, community authorship 25%	Conduct is impeccable: ethical process — consent, community authorship is demonstrated throughout, protocols are followed without exception, and the work shows active care for the people and communities involved.	Conduct is sound: ethical process — consent, community authorship is evident with only minor lapses that do not affect participants or partners, and all required protocols are followed.	Conduct is uneven: ethical process — consent, community authorship is addressed but with gaps — a missed protocol step, careless handling of sensitive material, or boundary issues requiring instructor follow-up.	Conduct falls short of requirements: ethical process — consent, community authorship is neglected in ways that required intervention or placed participants, partners, or material at risk.
Quality of contribution to the content 25%	The deliverable is excellent: quality of contribution to the content is met at a standard the partner or audience can use immediately — complete, accurate, well-organized, and genuinely useful.	The deliverable is good: quality of contribution to the content is met; it is usable with minor revisions and its purpose is clearly served.	The deliverable is incomplete: quality of contribution to the content is only partly met — gaps, errors, or unclear organization mean substantial revision is needed before it could be used.	The deliverable is inadequate: quality of contribution to the content is not met; the product is unusable, inaccurate, or missing major required elements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Framing analysis insight 20%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: framing analysis insight goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: framing analysis insight is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: framing analysis insight is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: framing analysis insight is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.